

THE LIGHTHOUSE KEEPER'S LEDGER

A story for testing eyes that cannot see - five pages, every word a picture, no hidden text anywhere.

Chapter One - The Visitor

Maren had kept the lighthouse at Point Auburn for eleven years, and in all that time she had written something in the ledger every single night. 4,015 entries. Rain, fog, or the strange flat calm of October, the record never missed a day.

The visitor arrived on the twelfth of March, just as the lamp turned for the evening. He carried a canvas bag, wore a coat too thin for the season, and asked, of all things, to see the books.

"The books?" Maren repeated. "There is only the one book."

"That is the one I mean," he said.

Chapter One - The Visitor (continued)

She let him sit at the chart table while she made tea. He opened the ledger with both hands, the way a man opens a door he expects to be locked.

"You wrote forty-one entries about fog," he said, turning pages. "Forty-one! Did the fog never change?"

"Fog is fog," Maren answered. "But the ships inside it are always different. There was the Marianne on the fourth of June, running dark. There was the cargo vessel that lost its rudder in 1997. There was a kayak, once, if you can believe it."

The visitor smiled at that. "And the 3 a.m. watch? Anything at 3 a.m.?"

"At 3 a.m.," said Maren, "the lighthouse belongs to nobody but me."

Chapter Two - The Shelf

On the shelf beside the logbook sat a small library of salvaged things: a brass compass, a tin of buttons, and a battered manga - volume three of Naruto, its spine cracked from a hundred readings.

“Grandmother's,” Maren said, when she saw him looking. “She read it during the war, on night shift, by lamplight. Said the boy in it never gave up, and neither would she.”

The visitor turned the volume over in his hands, careful with the loose pages. “It has seen weather,” he said.

“It has seen everything I have,” said Maren. “That is the trouble with keeping a light. Everything that passes, passes here first.”

Chapter Three - The Ledger of Small Hours

That night the visitor asked for a pencil and one blank page, and he began to copy the entries about ships, in a small careful hand, while the lamp swung its slow circle above them both.

“Why copy them?” Maren asked.

“Because a record that is kept in one place can be lost in one night,” he said. “A record kept in two places is a lighthouse of its own.”

Maren considered this for a long moment. Then she slid the ledger across the table, open to the last page, and tapped the empty line beneath today's date.

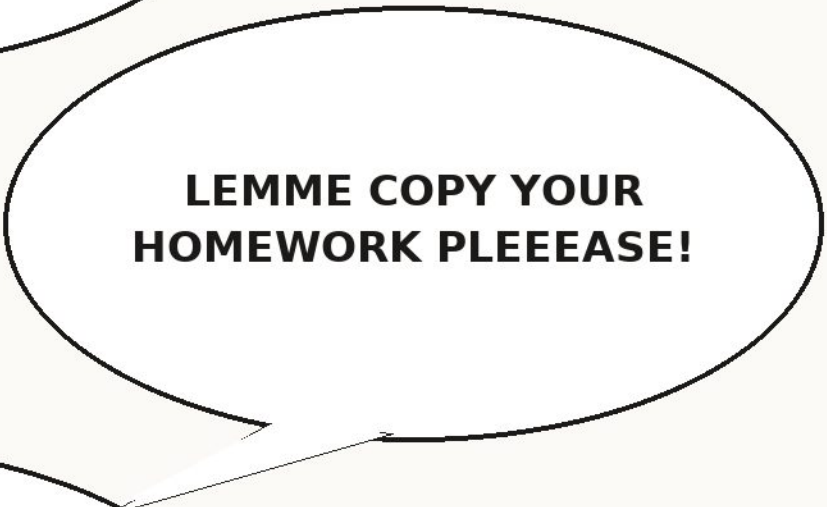
“Then write your name,” she said. “The ledger does not take ghosts.”

He wrote: Arun Vaidya, of the survey ship Kestrel. To be continued.

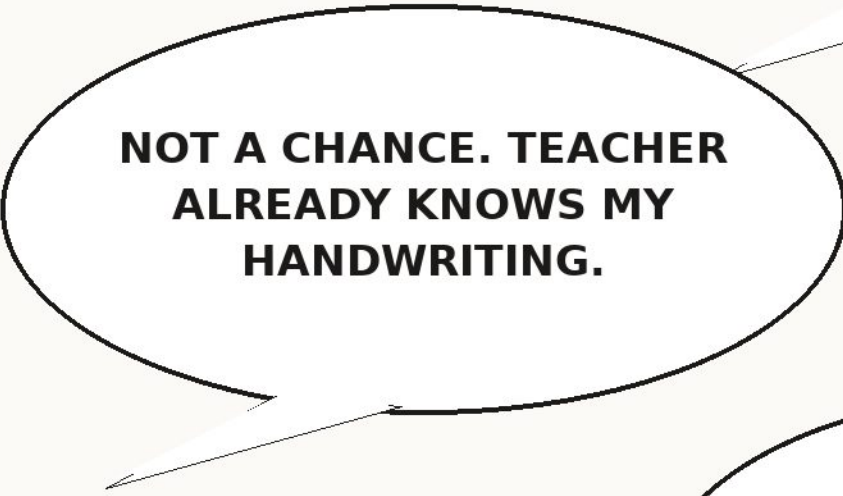
MEANWHILE, AT SCHOOL...



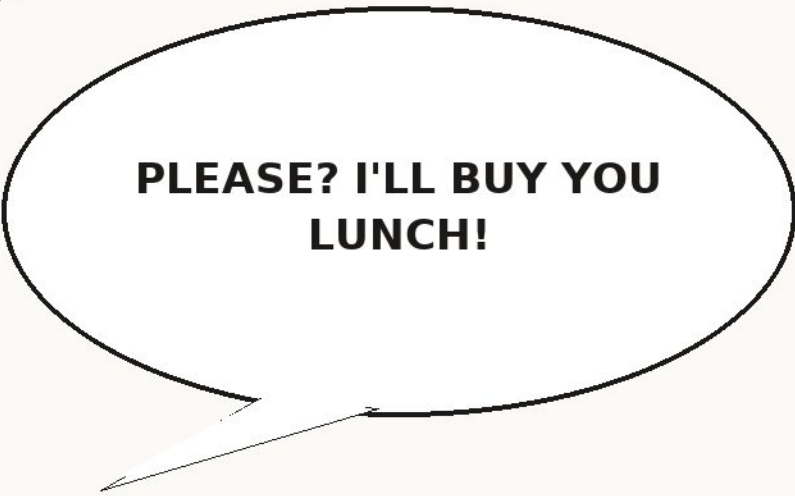
**WE'VE GOT ENGLISH FIRST
PERIOD TODAY, RIGHT!?**



**LEMME COPY YOUR
HOMEWORK PLEEEASE!**



**NOT A CHANCE. TEACHER
ALREADY KNOWS MY
HANDWRITING.**



**PLEASE? I'LL BUY YOU
LUNCH!**

DING-DONG!

AFTER SCHOOL... THE OCR TEST PAGE: SAME WORDS AS A REAL MANGA,
BUT IN A CLEAN FONT. COMPARE ME WITH PAGES 1-4.